

NOT ANOTHER WORD

a short film

adapted from the pilot by

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based on the life of Hunter S. Thompson

short film draft v1.3

INT. MILES' APARTMENT - LIVING ROOM - DAY

A woman's hand places a crystal glass on top of a liquor cabinet. Straightens a painting an inch it didn't need.

SHARI (50s), housekeeper, coat already on. Behind her, through the window, on the street below: a white van. Blue logo – DRAIN DISPOSAL.

She looks at it a moment longer than a van deserves.

She leaves. The apartment holds its breath.

BEEP. BEEP. BEEP.

The clock strikes 3:00 PM.

INT. MILES' APARTMENT - BEDROOM - CONTINUOUS

A figure stirs in the unkempt, unwashed bed. MILES GOODMAN (late 30s) rolls to meet the harbinger of the "morning." A hand stretches out lazily, missing its mark. One eye cocks, and with force, the alarm is silenced.

INT. MILES' APARTMENT - KITCHEN - AFTERNOON

Through an automatic stupor, the first thing he grabs is a bottle of Chivas Regal, cabinet closest to the fridge.

The cap twists. POP.

Orange caught by the light floods into the crystal glass – the one that was waiting for him.

A chromatic radio, dials crusted black from overuse. A twist and a popular song snaps to the news:

RADIO (V.O.)
... tributes continue to pour in
for the novelist Vivian Reyes,
found dead at her Vermont farmhouse
this week at sixty-one. Her
publisher reports collected
editions selling nine hundred
percent above –

Another twist. Music again. Miles wasn't listening.

From a worn wooden box on the windowsill: an unmarked pack of cigarettes and an old sailor's lighter, waxed rope coated with lamp oil.

He settles into his chair. Pulls a cigarette. FLICK.

The cigarette crackles to the flame as he inhales. Any tension held in his body from the night before releases – a remedy only the first cigarette of the day provides.

Raw beans into a grinder, a METALLIC GRIND. The kettle goes on the burner.

INT. MILES' APARTMENT - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

On a silver tray on the coffee table: a wooden box shaped like a bearded dragon. The YUNNAN DRAGON.

A hand opens the latch on its belly – a hollowed body filled with cocaine and a silver spoon.

A healthy portion onto the tray. Thin white lines.

He does what would naturally occur next.

From the kitchen, a rising WHISTLE –

EXT. MILES' APARTMENT - PATIO - AFTERNOON

— and the kettle SCREAMS somewhere behind him. Miles, in his bathrobe, doesn't move. Early autumn sun. On the iron table: coffee, the Chivas, the tray, the cigarettes. The complete set.

He pours a splash of whiskey into the coffee.

From up here it's easy to observe the street. Those people — driving their cars, peddling their bikes, doing their best on two legs.

Across the street, two windows in the same building. In one, a family sets a dinner table — a boy and a girl fighting for the attention of their father. In the other, a young couple having rigorous sex.

Miles watches both the way you'd watch weather.

Below, between the parked cars: the white van. DRAIN DISPOSAL. He registers it the way you register a cloud.

He SNORTS a line. Sips his coffee without breaking focus.

INT. MILES' APARTMENT - BEDROOM - EVENING

Red-faced, soaking from the shower, Miles paces with a red cord phone, speaking at pace.

MILES

... I'm telling you, it's a very, very simple switch that turns what at best is a passing experience into an unreasonably exhilarating one. The Sheriff had my Ping Beryllium, the 9-iron. I had his shotgun. He pitches toward the green, and my objective – my entire function, McGarr – is to blow his ball off course. Like a clay pigeon.

He leans into the tray on the dresser. Cleans its surface. Rises, swallows, reconnects his train of thought.

MCGARR (V.O.)

(on the phone, tinny)

Jesus, Miles. What time is it over there for you?

MILES

Never too early, McGarr. Never too early.

He's pacing again, well out of range of the receiver.

MILES (CONT'D)

I'm writing it up for the column tonight. You and the Sheriff are the founding consultants.

MCGARR (V.O.)

Can't hear you there, Miles... Miles?

McGarr hangs up. DIAL TONE.

Miles, unaware, keeps talking while putting on a tan suit.

EXT. CITY STREETS - NIGHT

Night has fallen on New York. Miles rides a bright red vespa to breakfast. At a red light, he sips from a silver flask tucked in his breast pocket.

INT. ASTERS PUB - NIGHT

Lively. Families, couples. Miles takes a stool at the bar – his usual booth in the corner is occupied by a young couple. He clocks it. Lets it go.

Above the bar, a TV plays a talk show. The guest of honor is Miles – wasted, in his best suit, delighted to be the joke in the room.

HOST (ON TV)
... I'd heard writers weren't
attractive folk, but c'mon, Miles,
you're really leaning into it!

Studio laughter. On the TV, Miles laughs along, delighted. At the bar, Miles watches himself do it with no expression at all.

A CHILD stands at his elbow. Pen and paper. Working up courage.

CHILD
Can I get your autograph please?

MILES
Hand me that pen and wad.
(signing)
Tell me, son. You know my name?

The child stares blankly.

MILES (CONT'D)
Your father put you up to this?

CHILD
Yes.

MILES
Well. At least you're honest. Not a
lot of that around anymore. Keep it
going – it'll get you about
halfway there most of the time.

The kid takes the paper and wheels away. Miles turns to find JOANSY (50s), waitress, notepad out. Her dutiful demeanor has something careful underneath it.

MILES (CONT'D)
Same as always, Joansy.

JOANSY
Maybe not tonight, hun.

MILES
I'm not following.

JOANSY
We've had some heavier business
tonight. Needed the larger tables.

Miles glances around. Multiple booths sit empty.

MILES
To the bar, then. I'm at it.

JOANSY
(a tender hand on his
shoulder)
We're not supposed to be expecting
you.

MILES
... This about my tab?

JOANSY
More circumstantial than anything,
really. I hear Allan's has a good
Galway chowder. For those who have
the time.

The comment strikes him as odd. He glances at the wooden
clock above the bar. Double-checks it against his wrist
watch. They agree. That's not what's wrong.

MILES
Good call. Evening, then.

INT. MILES' APARTMENT - STUDY - NIGHT

The streetlights come through the eastward window and the room glows a deep sodium-vapor orange. Bookshelves. A drafting table. An old typewriter with a stack of blank pages.

Miles, at the rotary phone, dials. Three rings.

MCGARR (VOICEMAIL)

You've reached the line of Mason McGarr. Leave your name and number and I'll get back to you when I can.

BEEP.

MILES

Hey, boss. You're not going to like this, but I'm the type to rip the band-aid off. I'm pulling the plug on it all. The book, the Paramount deal, all of it. Time I made my retreat back out to Aspen. Less going on. Plenty to do.

He lights a fresh cigarette.

MILES (CONT'D)

You see what dying did for Vivian Reyes' numbers? Nine hundred percent. Christ. Best career move she ever made.

(a drag)

Anyway. Wanted you to know before those androids come in tonight for that interview on me. I'll try you tomorrow after it all goes down. Godspeed.

He returns the receiver. Through the study window, the street below: the white van hasn't moved.

INT. MILES' APARTMENT - LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

Amber Chivas swirls in the crystal glass. The sole lamp's bulb is stained black from cigarette smoke. On the tray, a small fresh pile from the Dragon. Miles' leg bounces. He checks the clock, then his watch, confirming the integrity of both timepieces.

MILES
(muttering)
Christ. Not even Nixon drew anxiety
from the press.

The creak of the elevator in the hall. Footsteps.

KNOCK. KNOCK. KNOCK.

Miles remembers the tray – wipes it clean with a palm, licks his fingers.

He opens the door: a WOMAN (late 30s), grey sports coat, pencil skirt, smart and professional. Behind her, two MEN (late 30s), black t-shirts, black pants, large black cases. One wears a black toque.

STACEY
(hand extended)
Miles Goodman. It is a pleasure.
Stacey Bradshaw. This is our small
crew – Michael and Michael.

MILES
Michael and Michael. What are they,
brothers?

Neither man responds. Stacey smiles.

MILES (CONT'D)
Bad joke. Pleasure.

The Michaels spend no time taking in the apartment. Cases open: camera, tripod, small lights, a boom. They build the room into a television set – shifting tables, collecting his loose magazines, quietly erasing him from his own living room.

Miles watches them work. Stacey sits adjacent.

MILES (CONT'D)
Never really understood the camera
much. You bring all this machinery,
you create a situation that's
unnatural anyway. The technology
warps reality. It's a betrayal.

STACEY

In your line of work I'd have thought you'd spent plenty of time in front of one.

MILES

Sure. Doesn't mean I trust it.

A light nearly topples – caught by a Michael. The other Michael sets the frame. Stacey accepts a cigarette; Miles lights both; she takes one heavy drag and puts hers out.

THE INTERVIEW. Warm glow of the small lights. One Michael on camera, one on the boom. Miles smokes and drinks, entirely comfortable.

STACEY (CONT'D)

... are you saying you miss travelling?

MILES

No. A story is a story. It can be found and written any way you like. You don't travel for stories. You travel for you.

STACEY

But the lifestyle we've just gone over. Waking in the afternoon. Drinking immediately. The substances. A day's worth of food in a sitting. You don't think it hinders you?

MILES

For there to be a lapse in my writing, there'd have to be a lapse in me.

He loses focus – eyes drifting to the Yunnan Dragon. Hours empty now. He looks down: the Chartreuse is a mouthful in the crystal cup.

STACEY

What is next for Miles Goodman?

MILES

Don't even think the Lord could tell you that much.

STACEY

Is there a new area of storytelling you'd like to engage with?

Miles stares through her. Glances at the side table – the telephone has been pulled off the receiver. He doesn't remember doing that.

MILES

I can't say the pen is dry, but perhaps something else has become barren. I've taken the form as far as I can take it. I've started repeating myself. It's hard for me to work on a story – I become part of the story. First press conference with Jimmy Carter, I signed more autographs than Carter. The Secret Service thought I was an astronaut.

(a pause; quieter)

I used to stand in the back and absorb. I can't anymore. The myth has taken over. I find myself an appendage. I'm no longer necessary. I'm in the way.

Stacey glances back at her crew. Both Michaels signal with their eyes. Nod. She refocuses.

MILES (CONT'D)

It would be much better if I died, so people could take the myth. I have to solve this problem. Kill off one life and start with another one.

STACEY

So you have concern for your legacy, once you're dead?

This snaps Miles out of the rant. He grasps where he is. Shifts with unease.

MILES

I haven't the faintest clue.

STACEY

Would you be happier dead?

Miles notices that both Michaels are watching him now, not the equipment. Stacey hasn't broken eye contact.

MILES

I think we ought to take a break.

Ignoring the suggestion, Stacey pulls a newspaper from her handbag, rolled with a rubber band. She undoes it.

STACEY
I'd like you to take a look at
this. Page three.

An average print – headline, sports column. He flips.

On the right side of page three: a photograph of a younger, sun-kissed Miles on a boat off Lombok, flanked by two grinning men and a massive fish. Above it, in respectful type – an OBITUARY.

His birthplace. His early life. The first journalism gig. The travel writing. The first successful fiction. The woman he loved. All of it.

He looks up.

MILES
Fuck is this. Some kind of cruel
joke?

STACEY
It's tomorrow's paper.

Her demeanor has changed. Upright. Rigid.

Miles stands. Drops the paper on the chair like it's hot. Crosses for the door – quick, sober, ten feet from it.

One of the Michaels is already there. Leaning against the frame. Not blocking it, exactly. Just there, the way furniture is there. The other Michael calmly coils a cable, watching neither of them.

STACEY (CONT'D)
(gently)
Please sit, Miles.

Miles looks at the door. At the man who is not blocking it. At his living room, rebuilt into a set around his chair.

He could run. Somewhere under the Chartreuse he knows what that would make true.

He sits back down. Straightens his jacket. A man deciding, for one more minute, that this is still an interview.

MILES
I – have you slipped me something?

STACEY
Not at all. Shock is normal in this
circumstance.

The Michael to his right kneels, opens a small black bag. A stethoscope. He takes Miles' arm and listens for a pulse, gentle as a nurse.

MILES

What the fuck are you –

He goes to stand. The Michael on his left presses him back into the seat without effort.

STACEY

This is always the most frightening part. But I promise – you will come to understand what is happening.

Miles stops fighting the hand on his shoulder. Looks at her. Really looks. The rig. The obituary. The van he's been registering like a cloud all day.

Somewhere behind his eyes, the journalist gets there first.

MILES

(almost admiring)

You're not press.

STACEY

We're admirers.

The stethoscope goes back in the bag. A syringe comes out.

MILES

Nine hundred percent.

Into the neck of Miles Goodman.

MILES (CONT'D)

Jesus Christ – the fuck are you –
get the fuck off me – get the fuck
out of –

He fades. His hand slackens on the newspaper. It slides to the carpet, open to page three – the grinning men, the fish, the smirk.

MILES (V.O.)

(pre-lap; younger, sunlit
– the voice of the
photograph)

Waste of film and a waste of fish.

EXT. MILES' APARTMENT - STREET - DAWN

The sun paints away the shadows of the brick apartments, filtering through the trees, warming the dewed ground.

Michael and Michael push a gurney toward the open door of the white van. On the gurney: a black body bag, straps along the chest and legs.

Stacey stands smoking, arms crossed.

STACEY
We're certain we've collected everything?

MICHAEL
Everything listed. Study and bedroom, accounted for.

STACEY
You'll be held to that.

The two Michaels exchange a glance.

MICHAEL
You know it wasn't us on the Millar job, right?

STACEY
Doesn't matter. We're all under the gun here.

They load the gurney with ease. Secure the body so it remains fixed. Stacey takes the passenger seat. One Michael takes the wheel.

The last Michael grabs the sliding door – and before he closes it, peels the magnetic DRAIN DISPOSAL sign off the panel in one practiced motion.

Beneath it, painted and permanent, a blue logo:

SIDMAN'S RETIREMENT FACILITY

The door SLAMS. The van pulls away down the empty street.

INT. MILES' APARTMENT - LIVING ROOM - MORNING

Silence. The room, reset. Magazines in neat stacks. The ashtray, clean. The painting, straight.

On the side table, the telephone sits square on its receiver. Somebody put it back.

On top of the liquor cabinet, the crystal glass sits washed and waiting – for nobody.

The radio snaps on by timer. The morning news.

NEWSMAN (V.O.)

... the body of esteemed writer and journalist Miles Goodman was found early this morning in his New York apartment. Tributes are already pouring in – and his publisher has confirmed the collected works, out this fall, are –

CUT TO BLACK.

THE END